

Dogfight

Chapter 1: Tagging the Predator

The trial ended in blood and silence.

Hooks stood empty. Survivors bled into the Fog, their screams already dissolving in the distance, as they always did. Wesker stood tall amid the wreckage of smashed pallets and discarded medkits that littered the admin desk of Lery's, chest heaving — not from exertion, more from restraint. Uroboros still pulsed under his skin like a tethered storm, hungry and writhing.

There was often a kind of tension hangover after a match; the bloodlust from the fight never quite bleeding off right away even when there was nothing left to throw, but no good would come of taking it out on the surroundings. Best to just head home and wait it out.

He tilted his head, waiting. The Entity should have pulled him by now, tugging him back to the RPD station in that familiar haze of static unraveling. She was taking her time today, it seemed. Not totally unusual; some days the Entity took longer than others to extract her killers, and it really wasn't often that he got the chance to stretch out in another domain like this.

He stilled, every sense straining. Nothing moved. Even the crows were gone. The calm should have been satisfying — a clean hunt, quota met — but the stillness was itching at him regardless, driving him to idly pace the halls while he waited.

The halls were gray with dust, the sky out the stained windows a smear of barely visible light. Each footstep came back to him a fraction late, like the echo of a heartbeat out of rhythm. He followed the sound anyway, pacing through the ruin simply because doing nothing felt worse. The air pressed thicker the further he went, heavy with heat. Something sharp lived inside it, a scent vaguely under the rust and rot: copper, antiseptic... sweetness.

He took it in, curious, before he realized he shouldn't have. It burned faintly, a chemical perfume that clung to the back of his throat. He winced, annoyed, and kept moving. The smell followed. He hadn't noticed it during the hunt, entirely too wrapped up in the angles and vaults to really take in the ambient smell of the center. Now that he had nothing else to focus on, it was everywhere.

A prickle crept up his neck. The Fog's edges shimmered — too bright, too alive. His skin tightened, pupils contracting to pinpoints as Uroboros stirred under his ribs. He felt watched

despite the emptiness of the hallways. No matter how hard he listened, there was nothing to sense. He was positive that he was alone.

Still, this felt... wrong.

He turned once more, scanning the perimeter, but the world looked subtly warped — colors shifting toward a feverish spectrum, shapes sliding where they should have held. His breath hitched, shallow. Heat rippled down his spine. The viral hum inside him spiked in answer, apparently just as restless. He hadn't gone that much harder than normal this trial, had he? He would need to take a solid rest back at the station, provided the Entity left him be. Excessive fatigue wasn't unheard of, but it had been a while since he had felt its effects; and he had been running trials back-to-back as of late with very little downtime between.

Even a god needed a nap once in a while.

Another breath. A sweetness on the air. Sickly-sweet. Something acrid curled in behind it, coating his tongue, dragging a cough up from deep in his chest. If the Fog didn't take him home soon, he would need to wait out by the gate. Without the blood and bitter terror of the survivors, the institute really was impossible to linger in for long. What was taking Her so long, anyways? The halls were clearly dusted with her Fog, lightly coiling around broken pallets and doorframes, as if it somehow failed to notice he was even there still.

His stance shifted. He stretched slightly, one hand lifting to adjust his coat as if warding off the unease, his fingers twitched before they could land. A tremor flickered through his arm, sharp and precise. The air around him moved slightly, a faint hiss like an exhale from the walls, almost polite.

He recognized the sound instantly, the realization hitting like a slap.

Not fatigue.

He had wandered willingly straight into a trap.

A second tremor. His foot skidded half a step, as if his leg had forgotten how to obey. The Fog around him thickened, something in his head tilting sharply sideways. His vision warped like light through oil, and a sudden weight pressed behind his eyes.

"What—"

His body pitched forward, catching himself against a nearby window vault. He drew another breath out of reflex and choked on it. The gas laced deep, threading nerves, short-circuiting synapses. The infection under his skin reacted violently, veins blooming black as it tried to purge the intrusion. His muscles trembled from the internal war.

Wesker staggered, one hand braced against the wall, the other trying to ward off further contamination, burying his face in a sleeve. The hiss grew louder, seemingly from every wall now. A chemical cocktail working down into his blood, sneaking past Uroboros' defenses before the virus could even identify the intrusion. He had wandered too far into the building to get back to the outside air of the gate. The timing had been exact. This wasn't brute force. It was finesse. A slow bleed.

A calculated takedown.

"Show yourself!" The snarl broke halfway through, distorted by a spasm that clenched his jaw shut. Gold flared behind his eyes as the virus rose to meet the threat.

For a moment he almost held it — the predator forcing the body upright through sheer defiance, every tendon drawn like wire. Then the current screamed through the room, a white-blue arc that swallowed sound and thought alike.

Electricity tore through him, bouncing between muscle and bone in a morbid chain reaction. Not raw damage, *calibration*. A shock tailored for his frame, tuned perfectly to override every fiber of defiance. His spine bowed in an arc as he crashed back against the tile, backlit by flickers of arc-light. Every nerve still screamed, but the body that should have obeyed them didn't exist for a breathless second. Only pressure. A single, endless tone drilled through his skull while the rest of the world receded partially.

He didn't lose consciousness so much as slide away from it — a slow, drowning descent he fought the entire way. Muscles twitched in defiance, random surges of strength trying to pull him upright. The virus kept firing, desperate to restore order, burning through what oxygen remained. His chest convulsed once, twice. Uncoordinated limbs trying to push him upright, only to find their nerve signals either rerouted or straight up missing.

Somewhere above the god-awful ringing through his head, something ticked.

Bootsteps, measured and calm.

A soft crackle of static answered by the scrape of a metal instrument tray.

He couldn't see through the spots of white and black, vague sharp scents driving through the haze in the few stuttering breaths he managed — ozone, antiseptic, faint alcohol on a gloved hand. His hearing staggered back one layer at a time; first the hiss of air vents, then a voice, blurred by distance but unmistakable in tone.

The world tilted in stuttering frames.

His vision crawled back by degrees, a film of static peeling off the edges. Cold. Steel walls. Shadows moving with precision instead of panic. The Fog's usual hum had changed; it carried a rhythm now, electrical, surgical.

He forced air into his lungs. It scraped raw, but it came. His hand twitched, scraping against the tile, fingers trying to curl.

Move.

His muscles spasmed instead, half-fire, half-failure. Uroboros thrashed under the skin, black veins splitting and healing in the same breath. The infection wanted to fight. His body wanted to obey. But the signals were wrong — every nerve fired out of order.

A cold fingertip pressed against the inside of his wrist. Counting, clinical. Then a small, pleased hum.

"Remarkable," Herman murmured, crouching beside him. "Even subdued, your resistance is impressive. The Fog nearly reclaimed you before I could stabilize the dose."

Wesker's head jerked toward the sound, the motion sending vertigo knifing through him. He caught the briefest shape — the outline of a gas mask, white coat, gleam of metal — and tried to stand anyway. His knees obeyed a moment too late, his own momentum collapsing him forward onto his palms. His body shook with the effort, sweat and blood mingling in neat drops across the floor.

"Persistent," Herman mused, *"But predictable."*

Wesker forced breath through clenched teeth, lips twitching into a snarl. "You... dare—" Herman stood, baton humming to life with a lazy flick of his thumb. "I do."

The air vibrated. Ozone filled the gap between them.

"Stay down," he advised softly.

The next arc landed square across Wesker's back.

White fire. Every muscle seized, diaphragm locked against a pained scream. The current held for a full three seconds. Long enough for the virus to thrash against itself, for his vision to splinter again into black and gold, for strength to become convulsion.

When it finally cut, he was on the floor again, chest heaving, body trembling in the aftermath. Nerves sang, muscles flickered in uncoordinated spasms, Uroboros retreating deep into the bone to survive the assault.

Herman crouched nearby, studying the aftermath with professional satisfaction. The gloved hand returned to the wrist once more, counting beats. Steady enough now. Controlled.

"Even now, the synaptic recovery is extraordinary. You're actually still aware, aren't you? Well, I can't have you getting up too soon."

Herman loomed overhead, fog coiling around his ankles as the baton rose for a final, surgical strike. The blow landed with intent, just enough to make sure Wesker's next memory would begin somewhere else.

White swallowed everything.

He surfaced slowly, dragged upward through the sludge of unconsciousness. Sparks still danced behind his eyelids, mingling with a throb through his skull that threatened to take him back under. The chemical tang clung thick in his throat, every breath laced with metal and smoke. His muscles twitched without command — phantom echoes of the shocks that had put him down.

When his vision cleared, he wasn't in the trial. He was sprawled on the cold steel of the station floor. He pushed himself upright with effort, balance wavering. Every muscle felt wrong. Slow.

Re-synced. One hand pressed to his head, trying to settle the residual spinning from the toxin that hadn't quite finished clearing from his system yet. The movement set off a sharp sting in his wrist, as if something had cut into him.

His eyes dropped to the offending limb.

A sleek, black band, fused around his wrist like a parasite. No latch. No weld. It pulsed faintly against his skin, like it was breathing with him. Or against him.

The metal laid flush against his skin, and attempting to rotate it in place sent a sharp stab straight to the bone. The band had teeth, at least some long enough to reach down through muscle, grazing bone and anchoring it in place.

Embedded.

Wesker curled his fingers, flexing against the band, pulsing his virus against it.

Pain. Searing. Sharp. Immediate.

Agony punched through him, dropping him to one knee before he could prepare, vision scattering in a haze of static.

Overhead, an intercom speaker crackled, the Doctor's chuckles bleeding through the walls.

"Well, now that *IS* a strong reaction. Let me jot that down."

Wesker snarled at the voice, the intrusion on the only place in this cursed Fog that was his alone. To one side, the faintest movement of a security camera caught in his peripherals as it rotated to find him.

"What is this," his voice low, tight with fury. "*What did you do to me?*"

"Oh, don't be so dramatic," Herman cooed. "It's just a little... *observer collar*. Nothing too invasive. Think of it as telemetry with perks. It pings. It pricks. It occasionally floods your bloodstream with helpful mood stabilizers. And if you behave... maybe even a treat."

"You're still free to hunt, of course. Mostly. Just don't mind the tremors. Or the aim drift. Or the fact that you might forget what you were doing halfway through a chase. It's all part of the fun.

Honestly, you should be *grateful*. Most specimens don't get to roam. You're *free-range*. Very modern."

Wesker dragged in a breath, chest heaving against the static still caging his ribs.

"I will *end* you."

Herman's laugh was warm, indulgent. "Oh, I *hope* so. Otherwise — where's the fun?"

A faint scratch of pen on clipboard followed, his voice dipping into clinical detachment as if Wesker's rage were nothing more than a lab reading.

"Subject 06-W: Successful restraint application. Initial response: extreme hostility. Uroboros activity — suppressed but volatile. Further observation required."

Chapter 2: The First Misfire

The Fog unfolded around him, dropping him into the corroded halls of Midwitch.

The air smelled of salt, rust, and purpose; steel corridors, slick with condensation, the dull electric hum that meant life. Wesker stepped forward through it, shoulders square, the practiced rhythm of a hunter in his element.

Controlled. Familiar.

The sting of Herman's baton, the blackout, the unfamiliar weight at his wrist — all ghosts. Faint echoes. Whatever the Doctor had done, the Fog would bleed it clean. It always had. Here, he was still the killer. Still the apex.

He told himself that with every step.

And for a few heartbeats, it was even true.

A misfired generator flared in the distance. The first chase was a breath away, and he glided toward it, each step clean and confident. Feng darted into view between the pallets, her ponytail snapping like a warning flag. He tracked her automatically — angle, distance, timing. Uroboros surged at his call, pulsing hot and certain through every muscle fiber.

He reached for it —

And his arm stopped.

Not hesitated. *Locked.*

Every muscle from shoulder to wrist seized mid-motion, tendons pulled tight as wire. His lunge faltered, all power diverted into useless momentum. For a split second, his entire system stuttered: vision fractured into white noise, footsteps blurred beneath him. A static heartbeat pounded in his ears.

He swiped wide.

Feng, shocked for half a breath, twisted out of reach and bolted. Her startled yelp turned into a laugh. It was short, bright, *human*. Full of the kind of relief that comes with a monster tripping when it should have caught you.

She vaulted a pallet and dared a look back. *Dared.*

Wesker's jaw clenched hard enough to ache. He forced movement back into his limbs, teeth grinding as he ripped control back from wherever it had gone. The virus surged in answer, pulsing hot and agitated under the skin — but the pathway it was trying to follow had already been rerouted. Uroboros twisted against the resistance like a living thing but found no foothold. The misfire wasn't physical. It was command-level.

The cuff at his wrist pulsed again — a gentle thrum, almost curious.

He caught her eventually. Crushed her to the hook with brutal efficiency, as expected. The hook screamed as it accepted her weight; the Fog purred, sated. But the moment was already gone. The rhythm was wrong. Too slow. Too heavy. Not the clean predator he demanded of himself.

As the trial dragged on, the rot set in. A half-second lag on each strike. A stutter in the throws. Muscle memory corrupted. Precision frayed. He felt the precision bleeding out of him with each chase.

Somewhere across the map, a locker creaked open. Footsteps danced toward a generator. He followed automatically — but his chest was tight. Not with strain. With uncertainty. He adjusted. He always did. But it wasn't enough.

Every time the cuff warmed against his skin, it left behind a tremor. The next strike came a fraction too slow. The next throw overcorrected. The next lunge landed — but sloppily. A half-second off at every angle.

Worse than failure was the realization: he was no longer sure whether the failures were *his*.

Then came the pulse.

Mid-trial. No warning. The band warmed gently against the bone, like approval. A pat on the head dripping with condescension.

Wesker froze.

He was standing in the open. No one nearby. No threat. Nothing to react to. And yet — the cuff had reacted anyways. In the silence between the Fog's murmurs, a slow coil of unease threaded through him.

That pulse had meant something. He was being monitored.

Still.

Herman was watching.

Recording.

Adjusting.

Chapter 3: Futility

The return to his domain was supposed to be automatic, restorative. He should have felt the usual clarity returning, Uroboros smoothing through his veins, mind slotting back into precision.

Instead, the stillness of the station almost seemed to hum in a rhythm that matched the pulse under the cuff. Wesker paced like a caged animal, back in the far corner of the RPD station that was supposed to be his. The Fog was quiet here. Too quiet. A stillness that only gave his fury room to breathe and made every joint ache.

He dismissed it at first. The body always complained after a hunt. He washed the blood from his gloves, reset the equipment, sat at the edge of a bench and waited for the fatigue to bleed away. It didn't.

The band at his wrist warmed by degrees; barely perceptible at first, then sharp enough to feel like a fever under the skin. He flexed his hand, irritation a slow rise in his throat. *Fine*. He would catalogue the sensation, adapt.

His eyes stayed fixed on the black band clamped to his wrist. The faint hum never stopped. A constant presence: an incessant, pulsing reminder that it was there. Fused deep; bonded like scar tissue.

Even when he wasn't moving, he could feel it breathing with him, the long internal spikes scraping him raw. He tested the edges with the side of a knuckle. The band bit with a tiny electronic flare across bone and tendon — a polite warning that tasted like lightning in his teeth.

Somewhere above, the old intercom system clicked once — metallic, empty. Just the soft *pop* of a microphone live and waiting. He looked up, expression flat.

"Doctor." A snarl wrapped in civility.

No answer.

He meandered through the hallway slowly. At the doorway to the locker room, the cuff pulsed again — one quick shock that wasn't pain so much as intrusion, a shiver that scraped the edge of every nerve. He staggered a half step before catching himself on the frame.

“Childish.” He rubbed the wrist until sensation returned.

The speakers exhaled a whisper of static, like the sound of breath filtered through glass. The quiet reasserted itself; the hum dropped away.

He lowered himself to a bench, unwilling to show how much the jolt had burned. When he finally let his eyes close, the band cooled, almost gentle. For a few breaths he almost believed the experiment had paused.

A low hiss: a faint pneumatic sigh under the metal.

It wasn’t enough to cripple — just a drift of cold through the veins, a chemical whisper that left his thoughts too sharp and his body too heavy. A cheeky denial of rest. Wesker inhaled through the sensation, anger rolling up through him slow and black. This intrusion on his life had gone on long enough.

Trying for a more subtle approach, he tried to work the virus under his skin as a wedge; to have Uroboros pry at the connection from within. The infection liked to be useful; it liked resistance. For a second he felt the tiniest give — a microscopic loosening in the cuff’s adhesive bite — and his heart stuttered at the thought of finally getting leverage as he pushed harder. Uroboros responded instantly, veins bulging as oily tendrils writhed up under the skin. The virus coiled around the band like a serpent, lashing at the flush-seated metal, bubbling where it touched — but each strike ended in recoil.

It couldn’t grip. Couldn’t burn. Couldn’t *bite*.

He snarled.

Again.

Harder.

The infection swelled, pushing heat and pressure into the wrist until the skin trembled with strain. The band retaliated not with brute force but with bureaucracy. A soft injection hissed under the cuff edge — a gust of cool fluid, a bitter chemical bloom that stabbed at his vision and left organs humming with the taste of copper and bile. The cuff’s micro-sensors read the change and closed within milliseconds, a calibrated clamp that tightened an internal cycle of small, escalating shocks and a nausea-inducing cascade of neuromodulators. The world tipped sideways, stomach reeling from the assault even as his virus ate through the chemicals.

He turned, grabbed his combat knife from the locker bench, and pressed the tip against the faintest ghost of a seam in the band — a trick of the light, maybe. Hopefully, just enough.

The cuff sparked red.

The shock tore down his arm, a *precision strike* against the nerves that set his heart lurching unsteadily against his ribs. The knife jumped from his fingers with a clatter, hand spasming so violently it left his wrist half-numb. Uroboros hissed inward like steam into a vacuum, retreating from the bone as if it had been *scalded*. He'd never be able to hold the combat knife steady enough to try again, not with how hard his hand vibrated from the aftershock.

He glared at the band, breathing heavier now. The band had progressed from a mere insult to an outright *challenge*.

He braced the wrist against the edge of the bench and tried again, bare fingers scrabbling against the edge of the metal. The pain came instantly this time, a punishment for his efforts. It stabbed through tendon and muscle, a sharp, surgical burn that left him grinding his teeth just to stay upright.

Uroboros flared again in pure defiance, flooding up his arm, trying again to swell beneath it and force it loose. It couldn't cling. Couldn't anchor. It slipped off and recoiled again with a ripple of pain that shot down through his ribcage.

The backlash rattled his spine.

Still, he kept going. Dug his thumb in, tried to wedge under it. Nothing. Tried to pull. Nothing.

He rotated his wrist to the edge of the locker frame and *slammed* it once — then again. Then again. Metal shrieked and dented in. Skin split. Bone cracked. Blood smeared the frame.

The Fog shifted, the injuries vanishing like they had never been there in the first place.

The cuff remained untouched.

He dropped to a knee, growling through the hurt, one hand braced against the wall, vision tunneling away from the sensation.

For the first time in years, brute force had failed him completely.

He straightened slowly, breathing through clenched teeth. The band glowed faintly with heat, offering consequences he had no counter for in the moment. He could try to knife his way under it, tissue damage be damned, but every metal undercut carried the risk of electronic lash and organ-straining bio-doses. There was no doubt anymore — even if he tried to remove the wrist entirely, the Fog would just *grow it back*.

The station wasn't his safe space anymore. He was never off duty now.

And Herman was watching.

The realization hit like a second blow: this wasn't just restraint.

It was *ownership*.

A leash around his instincts. Around his choices. Around his *life*.

He may as well have been back under Spencer's thumb — a weapon in a glass box. But at least Spencer had been mortal. Predictable. Manipulable. This lunatic was something else entirely.

Smarter. Bolder. And worse of all: *amused*.

Wesker had been played. Expertly. Precisely.

And he would never forgive it.

When he tested his hand again, the band flared in a small, punitive pulse.

He tasted metal, but did not flinch.

Chapter 4: Breaking Point

He was eventually called to another trial, not that he ever had much say in the matter. The Fog spilled open, and Wesker moved like a blade in a shaking hand — sharp, but not steady. The cuff's hum had threaded itself into the rhythm of his steps, each pulse tightening its hold.

The first down came clumsily. Nea, screaming, kicking, was already hoisted in his grasp when the band flared red. His grip shattered open, tendons convulsing in painful stutters. She hit the ground running before he could force his body back into motion. A heartbeat later, the shockwave came — numb at first, then razor-sharp, crawling down his arm and shorting out his vision with static bursts and harsh glaring lights.

By the time he blinked it clear, she was gone.

And they had all noticed.

Dwight body-blocked at a doorway, something he never would've dared before. Wesker's lunge carried wide, nearly tripping over the man as the window missed entirely. Jake baited a strike at a pallet and ducked away a second early — timing gambled, timing *won* — as the wood splintered against Wesker's shoulder. Even Claudette, usually cautious to the point of paranoia, took bolder paths.

The more he missed, the more brazen they became.

And when he did manage to hit, they didn't flinch. They regrouped quickly, pulled each other up with the ease of a practiced routine. No panic. No fear.

They didn't know what was wrong. They didn't need to. All they knew was that the killer who once carved clean through trials now moved in fits and fractures.

The match ended with too many survivors upright, their laughter bleeding faint through the Fog as it closed. Wesker stood frozen in the haze, jaw tight, lungs burning. The cuff's glow sank back to its usual throb — unassuming, present, mocking.

They weren't afraid anymore.

They were *testing* him.

The next trial pushed him to the edge.

By mid-match, every swing felt ragged. The static in his head came in waves now, crashing over him seemingly at random. His body staggered on inputs he never meant to send. Precision bled away in stutters. Hooks passed without use. Grabs slipped without purchase. His kills dropped.

Quota dropped.

The survivors began to play with him. Taunting loops. Bold saves. Close passes behind his back. Jake laughed out loud when a fully charged lunge crumpled into a twitching fall, dropping Wesker to one knee with a frustrated snarl.

He abandoned the chase before the gates even fully powered up. He staggered into a deserted corridor of the realm, back braced against the wall, clutching the cuff until his knuckles went white, trying to will the world around him to settle. His breaths came harsh and uneven.

Uroboros flared under the skin — eager, aggressive — but recoiled instantly as it brushed the device.

The cuff answered in kind, sending a jolt down his arm that stole the strength from his legs. He dropped hard to the floor, gasping as the current burned down through his spine. His chest seized in painful staccato, breath coming shallow and uneven, rhythm knocked askew. Vision spun in swirls of too bright light that sent bursts of nausea through his core. Static crawled the walls.

And somewhere, unseen, Herman marked another note.

Footsteps.

Too cautious to be chasing. Too slow to be fleeing. Hesitation written into the weight of each step.

"...Wesker?"

Shaky, soft. Open concern. Someone who knew what a stupid idea it was to come this close. Someone who should have known better but couldn't help himself. He loitered a ways out of reach, visible only in glimpses: the gleam of glasses, the way his hands refused to lower the flashlight.

The Fairfield kid. Figures.

Wesker didn't lift his head, but the tension in his frame coiled tighter. He gripped the cuff tighter, breath hissing into a low snarl.

Dwight's silhouette edged into view — half-crouched, cautious, as if approaching a wounded predator that might still bite. He hovered just down the corridor now, clearly second-guessing his life choices, but still moving forward one trembling step at a time.

"You've been... off lately," Dwight ventured at last. "Kind of a nice change of pace, but...you don't seem... I just... look, are you okay?"

He meant it. The idiot *meant it*. Wesker didn't even need to see his face to know what that look held — sympathy. Pity. The audacity of *concern*.

It detonated something inside him.

Wesker moved before he could think, lunging across the space like a sprung trap. Dwight barely had time to gasp before he was slammed against the wall, Wesker's hand at his throat, the other crushing down on his shoulder.

"You dare to look at me like that?!"

Dwight choked, hands scrabbling uselessly at the arm restraining him, boots scraping for footing against the tile, but Wesker barely noticed. The cuff's glow flared red between them.

Dwight's gaze dropped instinctively to it — face blanching, confusion mingling with dawning fear.

The cuff flared again, sparks dancing over the band, firing a pulse like a hammer blow. Wesker's whole body jerked with it, the pain flaring down his spine and locking his joints. His grip faltered, arms twitching involuntarily. Dwight dropped to the floor, coughing as he scrambled down the hall and out of reach. Either he was extremely lucky, or something was seriously wrong. Wesker just *had* him, and something stronger than Wesker had forced him to let go.

Wesker didn't chase. He couldn't. His hands spasmed uselessly at his sides, and all he could do was snarl through gritted teeth as Dwight vanished into the Fog, fear and something dangerously close to *understanding* in his eyes.

He pressed his forehead to cold stone, forcing breath through his teeth into failing lungs. Every muscle ached, every nerve felt raw.

The Entity's shadow loomed cold across his mind, displeasure radiating from the Fog itself.

Performance: unsatisfactory.

Quota: unfulfilled.

No excuses.

The leash tightened. And the predator felt the cage closing in.

Chapter 5: Fault Lines

The campfire burned steady, sparks drifting upward into the endless dark, fading against the faint silhouettes of the treetops.

Survivors lingered in wary silence, jittery in the aftermath of something they didn't fully understand. The tension of the last match hadn't fully left their muscles; the regular flow of the trial having been so dramatically altered from what they had come to expect that nobody was quite sure how to fully let it go.

Dwight sat near the edge of the circle, spine too straight, hands tight on his knees. He wasn't trembling, exactly, but his body hadn't decided if it was entirely safe to uncoil yet. His breath

came short, shallow. His glasses reflected the flames in little red glints that flickered and danced.

He hadn't said a word since they got back.

Not until Jake broke the silence.

"Are you gonna tell us what happened," he asked, more edge than joke, "or just sit there like you saw the devil? You look like he damn near ripped you in half back there."

His tone was half-amused, but the tension betrayed him. Sure, Dwight had more anxiety than most of them, but none of them had seen him look quite like *that* before — pale, wide-eyed, barely able to stand after the trial ended.

Dwight swallowed. His voice was quiet. "He had me."

"Wesker?" Feng asked, eyebrow raised. "So what? He always has you."

"No," Dwight said quickly. "No, not like that. He had me— *lifted*. One hand. Slammed me into the wall, and then..."

He hesitated, frowning against the memory, trying to find the words. His fingers flexed once, then clenched again. "Something *stopped* him. I don't know how else to explain it. It was just us, and he completely had me, and then he just... let go. Not on purpose. It was like something hit him. Hard."

A silence fell over the fire.

Jake exhaled slowly, arms crossed. "That... doesn't sound like him."

"He's been *off*," Claudette murmured, almost to herself. "The last few matches. I thought it was just an off day or something, but... his swings are weird. Delayed. Off-balance."

"I thought I was imagining it," Feng added. "But when I looped him by the greenhouse, he full-on missed a corner he never misses. Like, *by a mile*."

Jake grinned faintly. "Sounds like a win to me."

But his smile didn't reach his eyes. None of theirs did.

Something in them knew it wasn't just sloppiness. Not really.

Dwight's knuckles whitened. "There's something on his wrist. I saw it when he grabbed me. A band. Black, with these little red lights. It was glowing — *sparking* — when he dropped me. And his face..."

He stopped again.

Claudette turned toward him, tone soft. "What about it?"

Dwight shook his head slowly, like the image still lingered somewhere behind his eyes. "It didn't look like him. It looked —"

He didn't finish.

He didn't have to.

The word hung in the air anyway, unspoken but understood.

Human.

The fire cracked, a log splitting with a sharp pop.

"Well," Meg said finally, arms folded tight across her chest, "regardless of what's going on... it's not our problem."

That earned her a few sideways glances, but she barreled forward.

"I'm just saying. If something's wrong with him — whatever *that* means — then that's good news for *us*. We might actually survive a match without getting punched through a generator. I'm not gonna cry over it."

"It's not about that," Claudette said, her voice uneasy, "I don't think it's that simple."

"It kind of is," Jake muttered.

Dwight looked thoughtful for a moment. His fingers drummed once on his knee and stopped. His eyes stayed locked on the fire.

"It felt like..." he started, then trailed off. He couldn't explain the feeling in his chest when Wesker dropped him. Not fear. Not relief. Something worse. The afterimage of being gripped by something so powerful it could've crushed him without thought — and then realizing it *tried* and still couldn't.

That moment of recoil. The mask slipping. The confusion.

The pain.

And still, the man had *looked* him in the eye like a feral thing in a trap.

Like it wasn't just about failing to kill — it was about losing the *choice*.

Dwight shivered.

Claudette glanced sideways, picking nervously at the hem of her sleeve. "Do you think someone's doing it on purpose?"

"To him?" Jake frowned.

"Why not?" she asked. "They mess with *us* all the time. Maybe someone is trying to balance the playing field."

"Sounds like they're doing us a solid," Meg muttered.

Silence crept in again, stretching thin and uneasy.

Across the Fog, beneath flickering fluorescents and old concrete, Wesker sat alone in the RPD's western hallway. One elbow braced on his knee, wrist resting loosely in his other hand.

The cuff hummed.

Not loudly — not anymore. It didn't have to. It pulsed like a second heart now, a low throb beneath skin and bone, threading into every twitch of seared, aching muscle.

He knew they were talking about him. Didn't need to hear the words. The Fog carried more than blood and footsteps. It carried *intent*. And something in the firelight across the way was pricking at him like needles behind the eyes.

They thought he was slipping.

They thought he was weak.

And somewhere, just beneath the wires — behind the intercom crackle and rustling vents — came the faintest wheeze of laughter, as if Herman could hear it too.

Chapter 6 - Judgement

The next trial began with the usual surge of anticipation — Wesker stepped forward into the harsh sunlight of Coldwind, Uroboros stirring beneath his skin like a tide ready to break. He welcomed the power, clung to it. It was the last thread of certainty left to him.

A sharp burning sensation stabbed against the back of his neck, but he rolled his shoulders against it, shaking it off. He had a quota to fill. Herman's little toy was not getting in his way today.

He reached for Uroboros, to bolster his speed and clear the area faster. The sooner he found the survivors, the sooner he could take them down and get back to the station. He felt the lift of energy, and without warning, the burning returned at the back of his neck, and the power was simply gone.

The virus stilled. No writhing beneath the veins, no familiar burn gathering in his muscles. His healing edge dulled and vanished. His body felt heavier, slower. For the first time in years, he felt only *human*.

He froze mid-stride, disbelief flashing sharp enough to cut. He tried again, reaching inward, demanding Uroboros answer. Nothing. Only the faint, mocking hum of the cuff at his wrist.

The survivors noticed quickly. Ace darted across his vision, vaulting clean over a pallet. Wesker followed — slower, clumsier. When he reached for Uroboros to close the gap, his body refused. Wesker's swing landed late, his knife bouncing off the wood, and Ace slipped free, laughing as he went.

Nearby, Jake hesitated before bolting off a generator, his eyes flicking back in confusion. Uncertainty etched across his face, as if he had just seen a god limping across the cornfield; but even he eventually joined in on the easy run.

Meg launched herself into the nearby shack and out of reach of his knife. He tried vaulting after her, legs refusing to align right mid-air, catching hard on the frame. Pain bloomed in his ribs as he hit the ground awkwardly. A window he once cleared with ease — now an obstacle.

The Entity's presence pressed heavy in his skull, cold and merciless, the spot on his neck flaring with heat. He reached back and felt at it, tracing the raised edges of a shape like a brand that had appeared out of nowhere.

A set of jagged marks in small circle with a line. The Entity's power limiter. He understood at once. This was punishment. Results had fallen. Quota unmet. She didn't need to speak. Her judgment seeped from the soil, burned in the light, echoed in every missed strike. She was the Fog. The trial. The world.

And she had deemed him *insufficient*.

Earn them back, the whisper seemed to curl through the Fog. *Prove your worth*.

Wesker's teeth ground hard enough to ache. To be sabotaged by Herman was intolerable. But to be stripped bare by the Entity herself — reduced, grounded like a wayward child — was a degradation beyond measure.

He forced himself onward, each step a weight. His fists still struck with brutal strength, but it was not the same. Every hook was slower. Every chase longer. The laughter of survivors rang sharper, crueler. They weren't just surviving. They were *enjoying* it.

And somewhere, Herman watched the data roll in, scribbling notes with delight as the great predator was left to flail as nothing more than flesh and bone.

It didn't take long for the difference to cut deep. Wesker still moved faster than any human had the right to. He still hit harder, his body honed by years of merciless conditioning. But without Uroboros threading his veins, his rhythm faltered. Every vault was mistimed, every chase a second too long. His instincts screamed to strike, to surge forward with inhuman speed — but his limbs betrayed him, sluggish and dull. Every second dragged with the weight of a body that no longer obeyed.

The survivors capitalized on the situation. Pallets slammed into his shoulders, blast mines seared his vision, vaults taunted him just out of reach. He should have been untouchable, a storm breaking across the map. Instead, he felt like a blunt instrument swung too late.

The cuff was infinitely worse now. Built for a monster, it tore straight through a man. Each shock locked his muscles longer; each jolt scrambled his vision harder. Chemical injections lingered in his system, refusing to flush out. His breath hitched in sharp coughs, his chest spasmed in arrhythmic bursts, sweat stinging his eyes as the toxins dragged him down.

By mid-trial he was bleeding from pallet splinters and generator traps, staggering where once he would have walked unmarked. Hooks came harder, slower. The laughter of survivors at the exit gate carried like knives.

He clenched his fists, refusing to yield, even as his knees trembled beneath him. Pride alone kept him moving, a stubborn refusal to collapse. But each pulse of the cuff reminded him — without Uroboros, without his healing, without his edge — he would just bleed out like any other man.

And Herman's notes would be *exquisite*.

The Fog reclaimed its pieces when the trial ended. Survivors were carried back to the fire, laughing and shaken, while Wesker retreated into the station's darkened corners. Normally the cycle reset him whole. Bruises gone, cuts erased, breath restored.

Not this time.

The cuff's bite carried over. His chest still spasmed with every uneven beat, lungs dragging against phantom smoke from trapped generators. His vision twitched in static bursts, a faint afterimage of the Fog's glare lingering at the corners of his eyes. The chemicals burned in his veins, heavier now that his body couldn't purge them quickly. He fought the instinct to retch against it. It wouldn't help, that much he could tell.

For the first time in years, Wesker stayed broken *between* trials.

Overhead, Herman's voice slid through the intercom, muffled by the scratch of a pen.

"Subject 06-W, post-trial observation. Damage persisting beyond reset cycle. Viral regression absolute. Healing factor absent. Collateral injuries amplified." A pause, and the click of a smile audible behind the speaker. "Entity tolerance noted. No intervention to preserve asset. *Most enlightening.*"

Wesker coiled inward, fingers digging into the cuff until his nails split. His pride demanded fury, denial, *retribution*. But the tremors in his muscles betrayed him with every breath.

Herman hummed faint approval, as if to himself. “Good. Carry it with you. That tremor? That’s just the beginning. You’ll feel it unravel. I’ll make sure of it.”

Chapter 7 – Fractures

The survivors gathered close to the fire, its glow a fragile shield against the endless dark. The Fog pressed close tonight — not enough to burn, but enough to feel. Like a wall just beyond the firelight, breathing with quiet intent. No one dared move too far from the circle. The scent of blood still clung to some of them, faint but sharp, as if the last trial hadn’t quite let go.

Dwight’s words still clung in the air from the last report. A cuff. Sparks. Wesker faltering.

Kate leaned forward, eyes glinting. “So what? We should be celebrating. His trials are easy now. We walk out breathing. That’s a win.” Her grin was sharp, but the tremor in her leg betrayed the leftover fear.

Jake tossed a twig into the fire, leaning back with arms folded. “Finally, some balance. Guy was overpowered as hell. Maybe the Fog finally nerfed him.”

“He still threw *me* over a generator,” Meg muttered. “And I’m not gonna pretend he didn’t enjoy it.”

“Well, maybe now he limps while he does it,” Jake quipped, but the way his fingers picked at a fading bruise on his jaw betrayed the memory of a very recent hit.

Claudette wrung her hands, gaze fixed on the flames. “You didn’t see him. He wasn’t just slower. He looked... sick. Like it’s killing him.”

Meg scoffed, but her voice wavered. “He’s still the one throwing us on hooks. Don’t forget that. If he’s hurting, good. He deserves worse.”

Nea’s voice slipped in, hesitant but firm. “Still doesn’t feel right. Whatever else he is... he’s stuck here just like us. All the killers are. If he’s breaking down, that’s not a win. That’s—”

“—that’s one less monster breathing down our necks,” Jake cut in, sharp. “I’m not losing sleep over it.”

The fire popped. Silence weighed heavy. Some sat straighter, pride in their eyes at the thought of easier trials. Others hunched lower, unsettled by the image of a killer reduced to almost nothing overnight. A line had clearly been drawn — pragmatists on one side, bleeding hearts on the other.

Dwight sat quiet, shoulders tense. He had seen it up close. Wesker’s snarl, his hand at his throat, and the look in his eyes as that power was stripped away in an instant. He could still feel the glow of the cuff radiating heat against his skin, and the way Wesker’s hand had spasmed away from him. He didn’t speak again. He didn’t have to. The fracture was already spreading rampant through the camp.

Arguments grew sharper with each return to the fire. Meg’s bravado turned scathing. Jake mocked anyone who dared suggest sympathy. Feng puffed herself up, boasting about how easy her escapes had become.

Claudette pleaded for caution, voice thin but insistent. “You don’t understand — if something can control him, then what stops it from controlling the others? What if we’re next?”

Her pleas only earned her contempt back.

“You sound crazy,” Meg snapped. “It’s not our problem. Let it break him.”

The camp fractured further. Survivors started refusing to share strategies. Old habits died first — item swaps, generator routes, killer callouts.

In one trial, Elodie lay slumped by a hook near the Asylum gates, bleeding out and begging quietly for help. Feng vaulted past without so much as a glance.

“Should’ve picked a side,” she muttered.

In another, Nea staggered toward Meg with a medkit outstretched, only to be waved off and left behind.

The compassionate ones were ostracized, left whispering to each other in smaller clusters, tension thick as the firelight flickered across their faces. No one looked each other in the eye anymore.

Through it all, Gabriel sat silent, his dark eyes thoughtful as the arguments flew. Dwight’s earlier insistence about the black band had set off something in his mind that he couldn’t quite let go.

When some of the more antagonistic survivors had been taken by the Fog for trials, Gabriel took the opportunity to join Dwight at the fire.

“Describe it to me. The cuff.”

Dwight blinked at him. “What?”

“You said it was seamless. Sparking. Fused to his skin. Tell me everything you saw.”

Dwight swallowed, then recounted the details — the red glow, the sparks, the way Wesker clutched at it as if trying to tear it off. Claudette added her own memory of his faltering swings. Nea mentioned the way he staggered between hits. Gabriel's frown deepened with every word.

"It sounds almost like some kind of conductor. I doubt it's actually seamless, it had to be applied to him *somehow*, but it sounds like it's been screwing up his attacks for a while now," he nodded, thoughtfully. His voice was calm, but the words carried weight.

"If it's actively controlling him, and that's a huge IF, then it's a risk to all of us. Rules are the only thing that let us survive in here. If something can break those rules, it's not just his problem. It's ours."

Uneasy silence followed. Even some of the pragmatists looked shaken, murmuring amongst each other with significantly less confidence than they had earlier.

Gabriel rose slowly, dusting ash from his hands. "That settles it then. I need to see it myself. Up close."

He wasn't foolish — getting close to a killer was a death sentence more often than not. But the real threat wasn't Wesker's claws.

It was the silence from the Entity. The rules didn't bend.

They weren't *supposed* to bend.

"Are you sure about this?" Claudette followed him across the camp, clearly concerned. People didn't just go actively hunting for the killers.

"I don't care what it takes," Gabriel replied quietly. "I need to know if it's the cuff that's damaging him... or something worse. We can't afford to not be sure about this. If something is changing, we need to be prepared for it."

Claudette hesitated, then touched his arm, voice dropping away from prying ears. "Just... be careful, ok? Whatever this is... I don't think it's done yet."

Chapter 8 – Too Close for Comfort

The Fog dragged them in silent, heavy. The trial grounds felt close today, the tight corridors of Hawkins too near, the light too dim. Wesker moved quickly, boots cracking glass beneath him as he stepped into a shadowed hallway. He needed to find the survivors before Herman decided to destroy his quota yet again.

The cuff at his wrist didn't spark today, just low hum against his skin like a warning, a quiet reminder of the threat against him.

Still, he moved better than the last trial. He had spent time getting used to moving around without the aid of the virus for the first time in ages, and though he was still sluggish and the coordination had yet to balance back out, he felt more confident in his steps.

The Entity could have done far worse than suppress Uroboros on him. He had seen what She did to some of the other killers when they displeased Her. In comparison, this was practically a mercy. He wouldn't waste it.

He wouldn't be humiliated again.

He found the first one crouched near a generator. Claudette. She flinched when he stepped into view but didn't run. Not right away.

She looked up at him.

Not with fear. With focus.

Her gaze flicked to his wrist, held for half a heartbeat too long, then up to his face. Calculating. Quiet. Like she was cataloging something.

She darted left and he followed, faster than he had in days. The chase should have felt good, but each footfall jolted aches and burns that wouldn't heal, and his prey kept losing her focus on fleeing. Her eyes had already moved on. Not to the door. Not to safety. To the *cuff*.

By the time he cornered her, someone else was watching. Nea this time, crouched on a ledge above. No flashlight. No attempt to save. Just eyes.

She didn't even flinch when he hooked Claudette.

Wesker caught her gaze, the first sharp spark of unease rippling through him, before dipping back into the hallway.

The second came when Gabriel tried to dodge a hit — too early. Wesker grabbed him instead, slamming him against a crate. He saw the man's hand move reflexively to grip at his wrist, not to pull his grip away but instead to grab at the glowing band.

He threw Gabriel off hard. Harder than he needed to. The cuff pulsed once in warning, then fell quiet.

What *was* this?

They were everywhere. Elodie baited a chase and never dropped her pallet. Nea looped him in tight circles that gave her no advantage. Gabriel cut close angles, always watching. No gens popped. No real escapes. They weren't playing to win.

They were playing to *observe*.

Wesker struck Elodie down mid-vault, just to make it *stop*. Her scream was real. So was the blood. But even she looked up at him with that same damned expression. Not fear. Not hatred.

Curiosity.

He hooked her. And left her there for the Entity to claim.

The Fog pressed close, pleased in the back of his skull, but it didn't matter.

He was being *studied*.

Not like a weapon. Not like a god.

Like a *specimen*.

He lashed out. Windows shattered. Walls cracked. His stride turned savage, all rhythm gone. The survivors scattered, finally remembering to fear him.

And yet even in flight, their heads turned. Eyes flicked to the cuff.

He caught Nea once — barely. She slipped the grapple with a blast mine to the face. His vision swam. A second spark pulsed red-hot through the band.

His knees nearly gave.

He snarled and launched himself after her, only to catch sight of Gabriel again — standing too close. Waiting.

A mistake soon corrected; his pained screams delivered to the Entity with considerably more vitriol than was appropriate.

By the time the final generator roared to life, two hooks had been filled and the trial grounds looked clawed through. Blood on the tiles. Scrapes in the walls. Several heavy crates cracked in the corner.

And Wesker? He stood in the center of it all, breath ragged, fist trembling at his side. His coat hung heavy with blood and sweat, eyes ringed with static flashes.

The cuff was quiet. But he could *feel* it.

The station lights flickered faintly. Wesker gripped the edges of the shower room sink, riding out a wave of pain and nausea.

A hum crackled through the intercom.

“Subject 06-W: survivor response escalating. Notable breakdown of cooperation. Factions forming. Efficiency decline evident.” A pause, and the scratch of his pen on paper. “Collateral observation: select survivors displaying heightened interest in monitoring equipment. Engineer among them. Pattern of curiosity spreading.”

“Unintended consequence. Subjects developing interest in apparatus. Will require... mitigation.”

A chuckle, low and pleased. “Can’t have the lab rats chewing through the wires.”

The intercom clicked silent, leaving Wesker seething in his corner, cuff humming steadily.

Chapter 9 – Malfunction

The Fog belched them into rust and ruin — a shattered foundry wrapped in chains and crumbling metal. Wesker hit the ground running. For a heartbeat, he looked like himself; focused, powerful, hunting.

Mid stride, his body seized, snapping sideways, his momentum pitching him off-balance as the cuff flared hotter than before. He slammed shoulder-first into stone, the impact jolting dust loose in a choking cloud. The roar he let out was guttural, shredded at the edges, humiliation bleeding into rage.

From then on, the trial collapsed into chaos.

There was no rhythm, no strategy, no grace. Just jagged surges and violent rebounds as Wesker tried to make his body obey. Muscles fired too late or too violently. One moment he hurled Steve into a wall with such force that plaster cracked outward in a spiderweb. The next, his knife

struck a deep gouge into scenery instead of survivors — every mistimed impact punished with a jolt from the cuff that lit up the room.

Sparks spat from the device with every failure, stinging the air with ozone. The world reeked of metal and heat and something burning beneath the skin.

Inside his head, the betrayal was worse than the pain. His body had never refused him before, not since he carved himself into something more than human. Now every strike mocked him. He could feel their eyes watching, registering each misfire. Prey *saw* his weakness. He would rather have died on the spot than endure it.

The survivors, though, didn't see weakness. They saw something worse.

An apex predator had rhythm: chase, lunge, recover. Predictable in its terror. But this? This was coin-flip chaos. Every time he rounded a corner, they didn't know if he'd miss them entirely or strike so hard their bones would powder. Claudette pressed flat against a pallet, tears leaking silent as she watched the red flare at his wrist. Nea crept around a corridor edge, hood half off, staring at the sparks instead of his eyes. Gabriel crouched low near a half-finished gen, studying the erratic stutter of Wesker's movements. They didn't seem so random now that he was watching closely.

They couldn't look away. And they couldn't linger.

Because Wesker's thrashing was still deadly, every jolt turning him more into a thrashing weapon. Pallets shattered under blows meant for flesh, walls cracked from impacts that should have been clean grapples. Metal walls dented where his fists drove too far. His voice was a storm, every snarl bouncing down the halls like a wild animal caught in a cage too small. There was no rhythm to dodge, no pattern to learn. Just violence, jagged and wrong. The survivors couldn't get close — every angle dissolved into chaos before they could lock their eyes on what they needed. They fled because to stand too near was to risk being crushed by sheer chaotic force. They weren't running from Wesker.

They were running from a bomb.

By the time the final gen sparked alive, the trial looked like a war zone. Steve limped through a hole in the wall that hadn't existed when the match began. Nea had a cut on her forehead from a ricocheted board. Claudette's fingers trembled as she reset a bandage that had soaked

through mid-match. Gabriel hadn't touched a gen. He spent the whole match watching, dodging, calculating, and still came back with a split eyebrow and a gouged side.

At the gate, no one spoke. They didn't need to.

Even Gabriel looked shaken.

Back at the fire, the warmth barely reached them.

Claudette sat closest, her arms wrapped tight around herself. "Those sparks..." Her voice cracked. "They weren't random. Every time he froze, every time he twitched, it lit up."

Nea shoved her hood back, hair sticking damp to her temple. "And the sound. You heard it, right? Like something shorting out. Circuits frying. I've built enough rigs to know."

Jake barked a laugh, but it was hollow. "So what? He's frying alive, big deal. Easier for us."

But he wouldn't meet anyone's eyes.

"That's not the point, Jake!" Claudette snapped, sharper than usual. "It's not some coincidence he's losing trials! That band is clearly driving him insane."

Meg laughed — too loud. "Oh, come on. A conspiracy now? What, he's got a car battery under his coat for the sparking effect? He's just slipping. End of story." But her bravado cracked as her voice pitched too high. She looked away, jaw clenched.

Gabriel settled onto a log, fresh wrappings over his side already seeping through. He rested his elbows on his knees, eyes on the fire. His voice was calm. Measured.

"I couldn't get close enough to really see," he said. "But it's definitely hardware. And if it's hardware..."

He lifted his gaze, scanning the circle.

"...then someone's using it."

The fire popped. No one laughed. No one argued. Even the pragmatists shifted, restless.

The image of Wesker tearing through the trial like a cornered animal — sparks flying, screams echoing, walls coming down around him — clung to them all.

The Fog hadn't just unbalanced him.

It had weaponized his suffering.

Later, when the others had drifted into uneasy silence or disappeared into the tents, Gabriel stayed by the fire — gaze distant, mind still racing.

He hadn't seen it close enough. How was it situated? Could he get it off? He needed a closer look, but there was only one way to get it.

Next time... he'd let Wesker grab him.

Not for long. Just long enough.

He had to know.

Chapter 10 – Residue

The reset came, but it didn't bring peace.

Wesker dropped to the floor of the station like a severed cable, his body refusing to respond with anything resembling precision. For a moment he stayed there — not by choice, but because his limbs simply wouldn't move.

He tried to rise.

Failed the first time.

Vision swam. His stomach lurched. Knees crumpled. A palm caught the wall — and left a smear of red where it dragged down the paneling.

That shouldn't still be there. The Fog was supposed to take these things — blood, sweat, breath. Pain. That was the contract. The pattern. The law.

But lately... the Fog was leaving things behind.

His body still heaved with the last trial's ruin. Every breath dragged as if through smoke. His chest spasmed mid-inhale, ribs jerking under phantom pressure. Something hot clung to his spine like oil. His fingers trembled. Muscles flinched from old burns that should've never made it past the gate.

The cuff at his wrist didn't hum. Didn't burn. Just sat there — quiet now. Patient. He gently prodded at the limiter mark on his neck and found the raised lines had stopped radiating heat. It was still there, but it didn't bite down on his mind now.

Maybe... She's easing off.

The thought barely held shape before it slipped sideways. His mind wouldn't settle. Thoughts spun. He allowed himself to slide back to the floor, leaning his back against the wall.

Even if She had decided to reward his efforts somewhat, the healing he sorely needed wasn't coming back. Not really. Not enough.

Something was stacking in his blood — something meant to be flushed, purged, *burned out*. Uroboros used to handle it. It didn't anymore. The toxins stayed.

Something hissed low in his throat. Not quite a cough, just a sound pulled tight through fraying nerves.

His hand flexed against the cuff. The strength was still there, somewhere — he could *feel* it, buried under the static — but it wasn't answering. Every movement came with delay. Every twitch rebounded wrong.

He wasn't lagging. He was **decaying**.

In the stillness, something shifted.

The quiet sound of pen on paper wafted, distant and crisp through the overhead intercom.

Shh-sstk. Shh-sstk.

Scribble. Pause. Scribble again.

Wesker's jaw locked. Not a word. Not even a taunt. Just notes being taken. As if he were *already dead*, and this was just postmortem data collection.

The cuff hissed lightly, a warm numbness carrying swiftly up his arm, making the lights smear. He squeezed his eyes shut against it, trying to dodge the nausea and instead finding fatigue in its place. For once, he welcomed it, letting his mind slip past seared nerves.

For once, the cuff didn't punish the drop.

The intercom clicked off with a small pop.

Chapter 11 – Control Group

The Fog opened on tile and steel. Dim lights buzzed overhead. The R.P.D. was quiet — too quiet. Wesker hit the ground running, boots pounding down familiar corridors. The station pressed around him, claustrophobic, boxing him in. Every scrape of his coat against the wall felt amplified, every echo biting.

His impromptu rest the previous day had dulled the edge but didn't fix the rot. His coordination had sharpened, but not his rhythm. His strength returned in furtive bursts of controlled violence, then collapse. The cuff hadn't sparked once since waking, but he could feel it waiting.

And someone was watching him *again*.

Gabriel. Obvious. Deliberate.

The man vaulted late, body-blocked narrow corridors, backtracked into rooms already cleared, loitered in view instead of working on the generators. Wesker's lip curled. The others scattered and played smart — but not *him*. It was like the pest *wanted* to get caught. Wesker ignored the obvious bait for a while, refocusing on breaking generators, on sending survivors scattering away with his blade, on keeping upright and moving. But Gabriel wouldn't stop. Again and again, he pulled attention back, always just close enough to force Wesker's hand.

It worked.

Gabriel clipped a doorframe as he rounded a corner. Wesker surged behind him, one arm lashing out, a hand catching his collar mid-sprint and slamming him with full momentum into the wall. Tile cracked. A filing cabinet toppled. Wesker loomed over him, fury etched into every line of his face.

The gloved palm locked just under Gabriel's collarbone, holding him there with pressure that bordered on crushing. Gabriel wheezed under the force, both hands locked around his arms like he could pull Wesker away. A mildly wet undertone to the inhales told him that he likely broke the man's ribs on impact.

Good. He wanted to observe so badly? This is what he got.

Wesker's breath shook. Every heartbeat sent a spike through his limbs — static-slick and heavy. The toxins were stacking again. But he didn't move.

He *wanted* Gabriel to see it.

The glow of the cuff shimmered along the killer's wrist, flickering with the rhythm of an overworked pulse. Gabriel's eyes tracked it immediately. Closer now. Too close. He could see the faint shadow of a line running along the side, and the way the red light throbbed like a warning.

There it is.

Wesker followed his gaze and *sarled*.

"You think you're clever? Curious little rat. You and your pathetic group, following me around like I'm some kind of sideshow... Is this what you were after? Is this a close enough look for you? You think staring it is going to make it vanish?!"

The cuff flared in warning.

Pain lanced up his arm. His muscles locked mid-hold, nerves sizzling. His grip spasmed for half a breath — and then he *tightened it*.

Not today.

Gabriel braced for worse — and got it.

Wesker pulled Gabriel sharply to the side before letting his tremors finally loosen his grip, the momentum sending him flying through the glass of a nearby window. Shards rained down over Gabriel as he crumpled to the small office floor coughing and writhing. Wesker sidestepped the weak attempts at kicking him away to grab a fistful of coat again, hauling Gabriel off the ground and marching him out of the office.

The cuff flared hotter against him, another chemical wash joining the current in an attempt to throw him off target, but he moved quickly through it to slam Gabriel back first into a hook. He barely managed a single yelp before the Entity's claws were on and through him, greedily hauling her snack away to be rebuilt back at the campfire.

Wesker dragged his breath through clenched teeth, watching the body vanish into light. The cuff went silent again.

But Wesker's blood wouldn't stop ringing.

The exit gates groaned open, locks grinding free as alarms wailed. Survivors scattered, shouts carrying through the Fog.

Wesker staggered toward back rooms of the station, rather than follow them for a possible last-minute catch, every spark from the cuff kicking through his frame like a whip. His breath rasped, echoing harshly through the silence. His stride faltered, weaving unevenly into the ruined halls.

Jake lingered behind, grinning through his bruises. He loved a dramatic finish — a final loop, a wink over the shoulder, salt in the wound. With the others already headed back, he wasn't about to miss a rare moment of fun without getting scolded.

"C'mon, golden boy," he muttered. "One more swing."

He slipped after him, trailing just out of view, boots light on cracked tile.

Sparks hissed again, bright red against the dim. Wesker slammed a hand to the wall, steadying himself as a dry heave convulsed his frame. For a heartbeat, Jake thought he'd scored the perfect encore — a front-row seat to the bastard finally falling apart.

"Subject 06-W," a voice drawled, grainy and pleased. "Tremors escalating. Cognitive resistance holding. Containment stable. Recommend further application."

A slow scrape of pen followed, then a quiet chuckle.

"You seem tense. Didn't sleep well, did you?"

Another pause. Then softer, amused — "Puppet still dances. Strings intact."

Wesker snarled, spine snapping rigid just as another jolt arced through his arm. His roar shattered into a pained yell as he turned and threw a chair at the speaker, sending it crashing to the floor in a shower of sparks and splinters, only for one on the other side of the room to start chuckling in its stead.

Jake's grin froze. His blood ran cold, breath catching.

He took one step back — then another.

He wasn't supposed to hear that.

The intercom buzzed once more. Then, faintly —
Shh-sst.

The scratch of a pen.

Jake turned and bolted.

Ch 12 – Burn Pattern

Jake stumbled through the Fog, shoulders heaving, eyes wide. For once, he didn't speak. Just stood there on the edge of the firelight, shaking, a bewildered expression on his face. Someone made an offhanded comment he barely heard about taking forever to get out of the trial — a light jab at best, but the humor died long before it landed.

Claudette noticed first, rising from her spot. "Jake? Jake what's wrong?"

He didn't answer right away. His hands were clenched. His mouth opened. Closed again. Then finally, voice raw:

"You were right..."

The fire seemed to still.

Jake's voice cracked as he stared past the fire, past the people watching him. "It's not him. This whole time... not really. He's— he's not breaking down. You were right. He's being *used*. Controlled."

Nea stared. Claudette's lips parted. Meg swore under her breath.

Jake's voice cracked as the rest spilled out, faster now, outrage climbing in ragged bursts. "The Doctor. He was talking to him like he was some kind of experiment. Recording readings. Mocking him like it was all just fun for him... I don't—" He broke off, running both hands through his hair. "He's not losing it. He's being *driven* into the dirt."

For a moment, no one moved.

Gabriel's voice cut in, low but sharp. "Then it's true."

"He's interfering with the trials. This is dangerous for all of us if it's allowed to continue. This isn't about Wesker anymore. It's about control."

—

By the next return, the fire was on the edge of a total fracture. The survivors gathered around the camp in tight knots, voices brittle. The fractures were spreading. Cooperation — the one thing that had kept them alive — was unraveling.

Meg jabbed a finger at Claudette. "You keep defending him, you're no better than he is. You want to risk all of us on some mercy mission?"

Claudette's voice shook, but she held her ground. "I'm saying this isn't right. If someone can control the killers... this isn't about sympathy. It's survival."

"Still sounds like pity to me," Jake snapped. "And pity'll get you killed. You saw what happened last time you tried to get close."

"We all did," Nea said, voice low but firm. "That's why we can't ignore it."

The circle of fire felt smaller than ever, heat swallowed by distrust. Dwight shifted uncomfortably, but Gabriel's gaze stayed steady, weighing every word.

Gabriel finally spoke, his voice quiet but cutting through the tension. "Look, this isn't about compassion. This is about control."

The group stilled, turning toward him. His tone carried weight — factual, undeniable. "If the rules aren't consistent, if someone else can tamper with the trials, then none of us are safe. It doesn't matter if you hate him or want to help him. What matters is that it can't be allowed to continue like this. We've survived this long because the rules were stable. Predictable. If someone like the Doctor can *break* those rules, we lose more than just our edge — we lose the *entire system*."

Dwight nodded, relief flickering across his face. Claudette let out a shaky breath. Even Nea looked emboldened. The pragmatists shifted, unease creeping in despite themselves.

Gabriel's voice didn't waver. "I got a much better look at that cuff last time and it's definitely tech of some kind. I was pretty sure before but now, I'm positive. I don't know what powers it, but it's definitely some kind of hardware. And if it's hardware, it can fail."

"We need to get it off him." Dwight nodded again, firmer this time. "We need to get that cuff off and prove that we won't be controlled."

Jake shifted in place, torn between his disdain for Wesker and the growing dread of what might happen if they did nothing. "I don't know how you intend to do that. Last time you tried just to see it, he damn near turned you into paste. What are we supposed to do if he turns on us in the middle of trying?"

"It needs to be a coordinated effort," Nea leaned in, determination building. "No matter what domain we land in or who we're grouped with — if he's there, we all need to agree on what's happening. If he shows up, we don't scatter. We *act*."

Meg let out a shaky breath and slowly sank back beside the fire. "Holy shit... we're actually doing this. We're seriously planning how to take down a killer. *Helping* him."

"If he's allowed to fall," Gabriel said gently, crouching by her, "any of them could be next. Or any one of *us*. And we don't have any kind of abilities working in our favor the way they do. We may not all agree on the reasons, but out here, all we have is each other. We can't let this destabilize the trials. They're dangerous enough as it is."

Quiet murmurs rippled through the camp. Glances were exchanged, discomfort shifting in waves that slowly hardened into resolve. Not everyone agreed. But everyone *understood*. Whether from empathy or cold logic, they had found something to unify them:

The Doctor's toy had to go.

Chapter 13 - Drift

The Fog discarded him into halls that felt too cold, too wide. There was no grace to it. No fire, no roar. Just a soft thud of boots, and a man folding like paper onto the polished tile.

Wesker didn't get up.

He breathed — at least, he thought he did. The air felt stale. Slow. He lay on his side, one arm bent beneath him, the other curled protectively around his midsection, trying to ward off the burning in his chest that refused to settle.

Eventually, he blinked. Not because he meant to; more because his eyes burned too long without it.

The Fog was gone. The lights overhead buzzed faintly. Somewhere, distant and high, a pipe ticked as if counting something down.

He didn't know how long he stayed there.

—

Time passed. Not in hours. Not in trials. Just... passed.

Sometimes, his eyes opened. Sometimes they didn't. There were stretches where he thought he'd moved, but when he looked again, the angle of the room hadn't changed.

Twice, he tried to sit up.

The first time, his vision blacked. A red pulse knifed through his chest and flared at the cuff. It didn't shock him. Just glowed. Like it was watching.

The second time, he made it to his knees before something under his ribs spasmed so violently he bit his tongue hard enough to taste iron.

He stayed down after that.

The intercom crackled once. A long, thoughtful hum. A pen, somewhere, scratched paper. Then silence.

—

He lost track of how many resets came and went. Some part of him must have moved. Killed. Delivered. The body remembered the job, even if the rest of him didn't fully.

Somewhere in the blur between one gate and the next, he still lifted bodies, still heard hooks take weight, still felt the world approve in cold pulses against the inside of his skull. The memory of it didn't hold; what little his mind managed to keep arrived as orphaned flashes, a hand slipping away from his grip, a generator flaring white in his vision, the sound of wood breaking as a pallet hit his shoulder. He came back from them more often with blood under his nails and grit on his teeth, and a cough that rattled deeper every time he woke — a pitiful little tell that he was still alive, a vague awareness that he had performed enough to be allowed to suffer again.

A slow breath dragged through clenched teeth. Too shallow. His ribs didn't like expanding much anymore.

He tilted his head back to blink at the ceiling. He knew the angle of every light there. The layout of every vent. Once, this place had belonged to him. His stronghold. Now it just smelled like ozone and sterilized failure.

The cuff at his wrist twitched; a light pressure, as if it wanted to remind him it still could.

He didn't flinch.

Didn't fight.

Didn't look at it.

Just stayed there, watching nothing, until the pressure faded again.

When he finally hauled himself upright, it wasn't out of willpower. It was because the floor had stopped being safe. His pride, pathetic as it was, whispered that he couldn't die there. Not like that.

He gripped the wall and rose.

His legs shook. Something in his left shoulder had seized completely. He didn't bother checking the mirror. The last time he looked, he hadn't liked what stared back.

He didn't know how long he'd been standing there. The room hadn't changed. The weight hadn't lifted.

His arm had gone cold from the shoulder down to the cuff. That was new.

The limiter at his neck had stopped burning for a while now. That should've been a victory, but he couldn't bring himself to care.

The cuff was quiet — simply because there was nothing left to punish.

The overhead speaker clicked, the gentle scrape of a pen drifting through the halls.

Shhhk.

Pause.

Shhhk.

Wesker's jaw tightened. Something behind his left eye twitched.

A second click followed. Then a voice — smooth, clinical, and utterly amused.

“Cycle 38. Subject upright. Minimal movement. Reduced reactivity. If I didn’t know better, I’d say we finally worked the tantrum out of you. Still holding, though. That’s my little soldier. You’re performing beautifully under observation.”

The intercom snapped off again.

He didn’t move.

Didn’t growl. Didn’t scream. Didn’t answer.

There was nothing left in his lungs to waste.

Only a slow shift as he let his eyes close, a flicker of heat behind them betraying some lingering fragment of anger.

But even that...

Felt tired.

Chapter 14 – The Break

The survivors came back from the trials bandaged and quiet.

Nea re-laced her hood with one hand, not looking at anyone. Claudette pressed gauze into the crook of an arm that had taken a bad wrench and said nothing. Jake rolled a shoulder that didn’t want to roll and wore his smirk like armor he refused to set down by the fire. Dwight’s glasses had a new scratch; he polished it without comment. They didn’t make speeches. They didn’t need to. Each return added a little more resolve to the air until the embers felt crowded with it.

They didn’t get to plan fully. Not really. Not as a unit. Not in the way survivors preferred — with maps drawn in the dirt, fingers jabbing out instructions by firelight, sketches carved into the ground to chart where the killer had passed.

They *wanted* to plan it. But the trials didn’t wait. The group was cycled in and out of various domains at random, never knowing which one would line them up properly. The few that did

manage to find Wesker only had the barest of outlines. Get in, take him down, get the cuff off, scatter before he could get back up. He was NOT making it easy for them, however.

Every time they got close, he would fight like a man possessed. The lack of coordination or patterns to his movement were almost impossible to plan around. The inability to tell who they would enter a trial with made personalized coordinated movements a joke.

The best they could do was settle on roles in the moment — gestures, glances, short stolen moments of whispered agreements passed on the fly as they adjusted their approach a little tighter each time. It was far from perfect, but each trial got them closer. Each attempt injured them less and wore him down more.

It was only a matter of time.

The Fog cleared from the halls of Lery's, Gabriel turning to check who his companions would be this round. Nea. Jake. Dwight. Each with a determined focus as they exchanged looks and scattered down separate halls. Generators were worked on with nervous glances around, hoping to at least ensure their eventual escape whether they managed their goal or not.

It wouldn't take them long to find him; their movements through the building were more strategic searches than the usual creeping attempts to stay hidden. Rather than scouting the best routes to generators, it became a basic path of quick moving glances into empty rooms that never really changed from one trial to another, and rapid fiddling with whatever machinery they tripped over in the process. The same wide corridors with their glass windows like observation tanks, the same antiseptic stink clinging to the drains. Glance, confirm a lack of their target, move on.

Wesker's presence was dimmed from its usual screaming radius that stretched half the building. The usual pounding of the survivor's heart whenever the killer was even remotely close was barely noticeable in the moment — possibly drowned out by the anxiety that comes with knowing they're about to do something monumentally stupid, but even without their scheming, his entire presence felt exhausted somehow.

He was stalking the outer wall, glancing up at the edges of vents with clear distrust, his pace looking very much like predatory control. But the way Wesker stumbled — barely caught himself — then squared up with a snarl, shifting his grip on his hunting knife as he picked up his pace, it was clear that he was running on fumes. A half-blink that lagged a fraction behind the glance, a footfall that landed a little too hard, the shoulder working against a knot that wouldn't

release. A glaze to his eyes that made him look like he barely registered the halls around him, let alone their presence as they stalked at a distance. Yet somehow still moving. Still lethal. Still fast *enough*.

Gabriel saw it and tilted his head the barest degree. Nea caught the signal. Dwight swallowed hard and nodded. Jake flexed his fingers once and let the breath out through his nose. This was *such* a stupid idea.

Alright. Let's try this again, then.

It wasn't clean. It couldn't be.

Nea showed herself first, bold and bright as bait, vaulting a window that offered only the illusion of safety. Wesker followed on instinct, knife coming up in a clean line that clipped air where she'd been a second before. The cuff gave a small, satisfied pulse, as if pleased to be consulted again after so much idle time. Dwight slid in quiet and knocked a hook out of commission with a practiced twist — better safe than sorry — then let himself be seen and lured their hunter toward a narrower corridor near the second ring. Jake came late, angling to brush Wesker's shoulder and steal a step, not enough to commit, just enough to irritate. Gabriel shaped the angles, never leading, only appearing where the path wanted to narrow.

Every second they kept him reacting gave the others time to set up. Dwight passed Nea a nod. Jake vanished into the shadows, doubling back. They didn't speak.

They couldn't.

Every time Wesker turned for the clear option, someone else was there — low, quick, moving with the kind of confidence that said they already knew the outcome. The cuff registered chaos and tried to punish him for it. A flash under the skin, an ache through the fingers, a tremor that was almost nothing until he needed that exact muscle to hold a grip. He shook his head hard enough to send stars across his vision and, in answer, found his knife hand a breath slow. He pushed through it. The next corner fractured. The next step slipped. Whatever margin he'd been operating on was narrowing by the stride.

The only sounds were boots on tile, rasped breathing, and the hiss of the cuff as it built another spark. Wesker twitched and snarled, but he wasn't coherent; his movements broke down under their own weight. One leg dragged. His off-hand flinched mid-swing.

They drove him past the old admin desk and into the corridor that cut the complex in two. The walls there held a ghost of earlier noise — his own, if he'd been able to hear it. He recognized the corridor without recognizing the memory, almost instinctively trying to navigate away from it.

He lunged for Dwight, expecting the man to crumple, not anticipating him leaning into the attack instead. He took the hit high on the shoulder and slid backward, staying on his feet long enough to draw Wesker three steps further than he should have gone. Nea was already there at floor level, skimming in from the side; her hand clipped his calf on the pass, not enough to drop him, enough to make him adjust, enough to make him choose.

Jake didn't wait for a better moment. He planted and drove a hard kick into Wesker's knee from the side.

It was mechanical and ugly and exactly what the situation required. The joint buckled, the weight went out from under him.

He went *down*.
Hard.

He hit the tile on an elbow and tried to roll, already turning it into a strike even as every nerve protested the ask.

They were throwing themselves against him before momentum could return.

Nea was on him in a blink, tangling his legs and trying to avoid the knife, locking one knee against a shin while she grabbed for the other ankle. Wesker's heel connected once with her ribs; she lost air and came right back on the exhale.

Dwight threw his full frame across Wesker's shoulder, grappling his arm and smashing his wrist against the floor until the knife clattered away. Wesker howled. The cuff flared red, sparks running in waves down his spine, nearly bucking Dwight off from the angle he flailed at.

Jake slid across the floor from the other side, throwing himself at the other leg and hip, catching a half kick across his flank before he managed to dig his hand against the nerves of the knee and pin it down.

The cuff read multiple contact points and made a decision. A held charge gathered without warning, pushed through bone with the precision of something that had mapped him long ago. Everything in his arm clenched at once. Every old burn remembered.

Gabriel *launched* himself across the final gap, throwing his weight on the cuff arm. He braced one knee against the crook of the elbow and set the other near the base of Wesker's skull, shoving his head away from the fight as far as he could to steal leverage. The writhing under him was barely held in place by the joined effects of the team, desperately holding on for dear life. If he got loose, they wouldn't get another chance this time around. This was the closest they have gotten to date. It *had* to work.

The stretch against the shoulder threatened to dislodge the joint from its socket, his head forced against the far shoulder making it harder to catch his breath than it already was. Hands were everywhere, digging into skin and nerves already far too raw. Wesker fought for air and found barely enough. He fought for a thought and found only panic. The sound he made was reduced to a whining yell, thin at the edges with a rasp that belonged to a throat gone raw from shouting and chemical burns. Every instinct he owned screamed at him to get out from under them — twist, buck, break *something*, leave someone on the floor — but the body he'd trained for years didn't answer in time. Every failed attempt at movement, every touch against the cuff only brought more retaliation.

And they wouldn't stop touching it.

Gabriel ran his hand over the band in rapid sweeps, wincing slightly at the feverish heat coming off it. He tried to rotate it, looking for anything that could be seen as a weak spot or gap, but it refused to move. Trying to force it to rotate freely only increased the bucking the group was barely holding down as it was. Even injured and clearly exhausted, the man was insanely strong. One slip and the lot of them would be thrown clear in no time.

He pried along the outer edges of the cuff, probing the line where metal met skin and finding nothing. Not even the faintest trace of a gap. Only angry red burns that snaked up the arm and into the sleeve, and a deep concerning line of dark veins spidering alongside them. It was fused flush somehow; clearly it hadn't been slipped over the hand, but it had to have been attached *somehow*. He swept his thumb across the surface of the metal and felt the faintest texture. There. The line was no thicker than a hair, but it was there.

"Dwight," Gabriel reached a hand back, gesturing. "His knife. Can you reach it? Pass it over. I think I can wedge this open."

Dwight snaked his free leg under the nearby cart where the combat knife had slid away, catching the blade with the edge of his shoe and flicking it closer. Sparing a second to shift his leverage slightly, he snatched it up off the floor, flipped the handle, and *slammed* it into Gabriel's waiting palm.

"Don't," Wesker managed, the word a frayed thread torn off an old spool. It came out on a breath and the back half of the syllable dissolved into a clench, carried entirely by the memory of the first time he tried the exact thing he realized the survivors were doing. "Wait—DON'T—"

The first drive of the blade into the seam unlocked something violent and cold. The cuff's internals fired a full escalation in a single greedy swallow, flooding the circuit into the bones it was anchored to. For a second the world narrowed to a point just below Wesker's wrist and then inverted. His whole body seized, his back coming off the floor like a drawn bow. His hands clawed without purchase. The cuff screamed through him, and he matched it — his own reply a *rupture*, torn from the very base of his spine. Every system overloaded. Every nerve ignited. His heart convulsed brutally, forgetting natural pace or function, as thought and sensation and function was torn free.

Gabriel's jaw clenched, knuckles white on the knife, and he pushed. The seam cracked under the force, hairline fractures splitting out from the tip of the blade to snake through the band as the gap widened. The stink of burned skin and ozone hit at once, sharp enough to make the eyes water. He shifted the angle of the blade, wedged it deeper into the widening gap, and pried. Bits of metal snapped and jumped away from the edge, the band positively shrieking against the assault.

The blade cracked the seam open with a final twist, the band fracturing in half. Sparks exploded across the hallway. Gabriel threw the knife aside and ripped at the cuff, pulling the sharp internal teeth free from ruined flesh — *no wonder it wouldn't rotate* — and flinching as some kind of off colored fluid sprayed randomly from the damaged mechanism to mix with the blood that was spreading across the floor.

Gabriel threw it away from himself and down the corridor without thinking. The voltage that arced through the metal as it left his hand reached back like a last insult and ran up his arm and into his teeth, sending him flinching into himself with a sharp snap that numbed his entire spine and smeared the lights behind his eyes.

The hallway took a deep breath when the screaming stopped, and for a moment, no one moved.

Nea's arms were shaking. She pushed herself backward, staring at Wesker's still form as if expecting him to leap up and resume rearranging their limbs any second.

"Is he... Did we just..."

Dwight rolled off the pinned shoulder and got to his feet on the second try, scooping Nea up by the elbow.

"Come on. We gotta go."

She allowed herself to be hauled swiftly away, reluctantly glancing back one more time at the violence that was spread out across the hall before vanishing around the corner.

Jake didn't move at first, chest rising too fast, eyes flicking between Wesker and the wrecked band on the floor. Then he swore under his breath, grabbed Gabriel by the back of his shirt, and pulled him out of the potential swing radius. After all that, he wasn't about to risk the killer regaining his senses and decided to take revenge.

"You with me?" Jake's voice pitched low, urgency bleeding through as he tapped Gabriel's face lightly, trying to get his eyes to focus.

"Good. I'm good. Just — numb." Gabriel coughed. "Go. Go — I'm right behind you."

Jake squeezed his collar once and let go. "Catch up or I'm coming back for you."

"Go. Make sure they get out. I'm alright. Just need a minute."

Jake gave a short nod and jogged off after the others.

The corridor was suddenly very large and very empty. The piece of metal lying 20 feet away from Wesker's hand was still leaking tiny, spitting complaints into the air. The man himself hadn't moved since the cuff came free. He was bleeding against the cement, the harsh smell of iron and something sour filled the space, and Gabriel couldn't tell in the moment if he had even survived.

Blinking away the shock haze, he rolled to his knees and hauled himself closer. He wasn't sure why he was keeping his voice down — habit, maybe. Something in him didn't want to wake anything else. He touched two fingers to Wesker's neck and waited past the first nothing. The skin was hot and damp and smelled wrong. For a few tense moments, he couldn't find a pulse. What even happened to killers if they died? Did they have a place they were rebuilt to the way the survivors did?

Gabriel frowned and shifted his hand slightly, and there it was: a small, stubborn movement against his fingertips, a flutter that wasn't rhythm but could be again if given time.

He let out a breath he hadn't noticed holding. He turned Wesker's wrist gently with his free hand and watched, fascinated and horrified, as the torn edges of skin twitched and tried to think about knitting. It wasn't a miracle. It wasn't fast. It was work performed by something that had been denied work for weeks. Thin strands of damaged pulp reached out for others, slowly trying to staunch bleeding and rebuild muscle. On reflex, or possibly some buried compassion, Gabriel pulled an old bandana out of his back pocket and wound it tightly around the gore. At least he wasn't going to bleed out on the floor after everything. The rest... well that was out of Gabriel's hands now. Time would tell if it was all worth it, or if they had just repaired their own execution.

He got up slowly on unsteady legs, hissing lightly as waking nerves protested the movement. The broken cuff still sparked gently against the floor, whatever fluid it had been spraying now collecting in a puddle around the shards. He put his heel on it and drove his weight down until the housing buckled and the last of the teeth bent in on themselves for good measure, scattering what remained with the side of his shoe.

Gabriel leaned against the wall with one hand and worked his way to join up with the rest of the survivors.

The Fog coiled around Wesker, waiting for them to leave so it could take what was left of him home.

Chapter 15 – Recalibration

The Fog didn't release him — it dropped him. Discarded back to the station, barely short of tumbling down the front steps.

Cold tile rushed up to meet him, the impact punching air out of abused lungs and pain into every inch of his body. His spine arched, air rasping in through clenched teeth. Every nerve screamed at once, awareness wrenched cruelly back from the void.

Everything either burned or didn't register at all. His body couldn't decide which.

The world existed in fragments: the buzz of failing lights, the taste of metal in his teeth, a flash of white restraint and hands digging into limbs he could barely control. Muscle tremors chased each other down his arms. His wrist—

God, his wrist.

It throbbed like a second heart. Still bleeding. Still raw. But when he tried to flex the fingers of that hand, they moved. Sluggishly. Imperfectly.

He opened his eyes, squinting against the sterile overhead lighting. It buzzed like a swarm of hornets, fluorescent and cold, washing his vision in pale flicker.

Movement tugged at his peripheral. Something dark and crumpled near his arm. He forced his head to turn and found a dark scrap of cloth tied around the wrist — blood-black, soaked

through, improvised. Tight. Too tight.

For one sharp, irrational second, panic surged — restraint, tightness, pressure around the injury—

—but as he grabbed at it to pull it away, his fingers sunk into softness where there was once solid resistance. There was skin beneath the cloth. Not metal. No embedded teeth biting into bone. No hum crawling under the nerves.

The cuff was gone.

His breath hitched.

He stared at the soaked bandana like it might vanish if he blinked.

He didn't know how long he stayed there — only that the thought of moving felt like digging through tar. Somewhere, logic tried to wake up: the survivors, the fight, the knife — hands, entirely too many hands, holding him down while something *gave way*.

They helped him.

Why?

His thoughts slipped sideways again, fragments scattering before he could catch them, too many systems failing to stay upright at once.

He let himself fall with them. The tile was cool. Unmoving. Safe enough. Maybe he'd feel less like scorched earth tomorrow.

He closed his eyes as exhaustion seeped back in, his body sinking under its own weight. For the first time in weeks, the silence didn't hurt.

As he let rest take his mind from the pain, something stirred gently beneath the skin — faint, sluggish, but there.

A pulse. A twitch of black beneath the veins.

Uroboros.

Healing slower than it ever had, but *healing all the same*.

The footage looped.

Frame by frame: a blur of limbs, a flash of steel, the cuff's detonation flaring across the screen with enough discharged energy to reduce the footage to static for a time. Then the aftermath — Wesker down, the survivors scattering like startled birds.

On the desk, the cuff's remains laid in a mangled heap: metal blackened, circuits cracked, the faint stink of burnt insulation still clinging to it. Useless now.

Months of sample collecting. Calibration. Research. Resources spent and prototypes lost. Countless trials. All of it — undone. Ruined by four bleeding nobodies with just enough luck to get in his way.

Wesker would be out of commission for days, minimum. And he would never be that easy to corner again. That experiment, for all intents and purposes, was over.

Herman closed the connection to the RPD feed with an annoyed huff.

There was no reason to watch his failed toy twitch on the ground.

He leaned back in the office chair, watching the playback one last time, replaying the moment it all began to fail. The survivors closing in. The pile-on. The knife. The break.

He dragged his eyes from the video to the telemetry panel. The cuff's data stream in the final seconds: readouts spiked red across every channel — neural lock, cardiac suppression, total motor collapse. An overload so complete it nearly killed a demigod.

For a heartbeat, even *the Entity's* signal drops.

Herman exhaled a laugh. “Magnificent.”

His eyes flicked back to the footage just in time to catch the cuff’s final arc — when the discharged current jumped to the survivor who removed it, the recoil throwing him back.

Herman pauses the frame. Studies it.

Conductive discharge. Precision voltage. Adaptive response. Interesting.
Yes... there’s something there.

Herman's gaze lowered to his own arms, tracing the familiar lines of embedded wire diving in and out of the skin. If he could replicate that — fine-tune it, refine it —

If he could isolate that charge — not random, not chaotic — but *directed*, refined—

His mori could become something *more*.

Not just efficient. Not merely brutal.

Art.

He straightens slowly, pulling up the telemetry logs, eyes hungry as he scrolls. The cuff was made for one body. Too specific. Too delicate. The average human body is messier. Variable.

It would need to be consistent. Measured. Flexible within a narrow range. Calibrated to multiple subjects. A proper formula. A real challenge to get just right.

Which meant he would need test subjects.

A pity about Wesker — but failures only prove the system works, even if for a time. Fortunately, survivors were much easier to collect than killers. And it had been so very long since he had truly challenged himself.

The Entity hadn’t stopped him before. And that, at least to him, was permission enough.

He closed the failed file marked *06-W*.
Opened a new one.

EXPERIMENT 07 – Electrophysiological Adaptation Trials.

His pen scratched across the page.
A note. A hum. A smile that didn't reach his eyes.

The lights flickered — patient, waiting.

“Let's begin again.”